

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 873

By Walley

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor Beene Farms in Chester County as a Tennessee Century Farm.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly honor those exceptional farming families who, through their dedication to the ancient and esteemed traditions of agriculture, have made significant contributions to their respective communities and to this State; and

WHEREAS, the Beene family of Chester County ranks among those estimable Tennessee farming families, and Beene Farms, owned and operated by the family since 1898, has been designated a Tennessee Century Farm in recognition of its long and illustrious history; and

WHEREAS, the Century Farms program was established by the State in 1975 through the Department of Agriculture to recognize the dedication and contributions of those families who have retained ownership of the same farm for more than a century, persevering through succeeding generations and coping with wars, floods, droughts, economic crises, and other obstacles presented by way of natural and human intervention; and

WHEREAS, located in the Montezuma community outside of Henderson in Chester County, Beene Farms traces its origin to the turn of the twentieth century, when John and Ena Smithson moved from Illinois to establish their farm in 1898; at that time, labor was scarce, and all members of the household were expected to contribute to the work of the farm; and

WHEREAS, the Smithson family played an active role in the development of the surrounding community, helping to establish the area's first Methodist church and the first local store, providing food and everyday items for home and farm use; on the original sixty-five-acre farm, the family raised corn, cotton, cows, pigs, and horses; and

WHEREAS, Sam Beene and his son, Horace Beene, embodied the heart of the farm's mid-century legacy, carrying it forward through hard work, perseverance, and a deep personal connection to the land; after Cornelia Smithson Beene and Sam Beene assumed ownership in 1932, Sam, shaped by a difficult upbringing, worked the farm tirelessly into his nineties and expanded its operations by introducing sheep, reflecting both resilience and innovation; and

WHEREAS, following World War II, Horace Beene returned from military service in Europe to work beside his father and eventually purchased the farm, where his love of horses and his habit of spending long days with his sons walking in the fields and watching crops defined his stewardship; even after a devastating tornado in 1958 forced the family to rebuild, Horace Beene's commitment to the farm never wavered, strengthening the family's generational bond to the land; and

WHEREAS, today, the farm is owned and operated by Anthony Beene, a great-grandson of the founders, along with his brother, Sammy Beene; his son, Alex Beene; and his nephew, Jacob Beene; the farm has been further supported by family members Lisa Beene, Blake White, Lauren White, Brayden White, Cassidy Beene, Ann Vernon, and Deidra Beene, now deceased. The farm currently produces soybeans and cotton, continuing a multi-generational legacy of agriculture in Chester County; and

WHEREAS, the success of this State, the strength of its communities, and the overall vitality of our society depend, in great measure, on the dedication of those such as the owners of the Beene Farms, who demonstrate a deep respect for tradition and hard work and a love for the land; and

WHEREAS, we find it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud this distinguished family for their dedication to agriculture, recognizing the importance of the family farm to our rural communities and the State of Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH
GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF
REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor the Beene family upon their
farm's designation as a Tennessee Century Farm, commend their dedication to agriculture, and
wish them much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared
for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to
the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear
without House or Senate designation.